and Haryana High Court. However that case proceeds, Mann still faces a whole litany of challenges on other fronts.

Take education. Earlier, state finance minister Harpal Cheema had elaborated on how the Punjab government is committed to working on the sector on the lines of the "Delhi model of education", which includes raising the standards of state-run schools, zeroing in on schools of eminence and building a young entrepreneurs programme. That has entailed a Rs 14,000 crore outlay—9 per cent of the state budget—on school education alone this year.

Despite a financial crunch, Mann had also announced in May that his government would purchase pulses at MSP. As a policy idea, it's a big one that seeks to wean Punjab's farmers away from the monocrop 'rice-or-wheat' culture. The harvest season was already on, however, so the scheme didn't give the desired results in its first outing; 90 per cent of the crop was bought by private players and most of it fetched 15 to 32 per cent less than the MSP of Rs 7,275 per quintal. Mann also implemented the poll promise of free electricity of up to 300 units per household from July 1. The state will have to make provisions for an additional Rs 1,800 crore, in addition to the existing corpus of Rs 3,988 crore, to come good on that promise.

Trouble is, Mann has little room for fiscal manoeuvreing. The state has a debt of Rs 2.84 lakh crore, and that could go up to Rs 3.05 lakh crore by the end of this fiscal. Especially since the state has been unable to convince the Centre on GST compensations, and is expected to struggle to reach the projected revenues of Rs 95,400 crore.

Policy experts say Mann has to do much more to be seen as a decisive leader. On July 11, he scrapped a proposed textile park near the Mattewara forest area in Ludhiana—a project he himself had announced two weeks before. The CM had even informed the assembly that 954.51 acres of the total 1,000 acres needed for it had been acquired. He apparently developed cold feet after a series of protests and the troll army pulled out his old videos protesting the same project during the Amarinder Singh regime. "The move has exposed his immaturity and inexperience," says opposition leader Pratap Singh Bajwa of the Congress. Mann has since had a meeting with environmentalists and assured them that no permission will be given to any project on the river banks.

It hasn't helped that AAP in Punjab has been in continuous firefighting mode after the bypoll debacle in Sangrur—the nucleus around which the party grew in Punjab, and the only Lok Sabha seat in the country it retained in 2019. Mann had vacated the seat to take up the CM's post in March this year. Ashutosh Kumar, who teaches political science at Panjab University, says the defeat has inevitably had an adverse impact on the Mann government—goading it into nervous course corrections that, in turn, led to more controversies.

Chadha's appointment as 'advisor' is already being challenged in the high court, on the grounds that it's akin to "a parallel government". A complaint has also been lodged with the President's office seeking Chadha's disqualification from the Rajya Sabha as this is an 'office of profit'. AAP leaders have been quick on the defence. Party spokesperson Malwinder Singh Kang cited Chadha's credentials as a chartered accountant and London School of Economics alumnus, his role in helping turn Delhi into "a revenue surplus state" as an honorary consultant for the AAP government there, and also how the Jalandhar native was not being paid for the job.

BJP state general secretary Subhash Sharma is unconvinced. "It's the job of the council of ministers to advise the CM with the aid of the bureaucrats, what is Chadha's locus standi?" he asks. This point touches a raw nerve. Political commentator Jagtar Sandhu says subregional aspirations run high in Punjab. The idea of a 'central leadership' calling the shots in the state does not go down well with a substantial section.

Meanwhile, Mann got into another tangle with a miscalculated tweet seeking land in Chandigarh, the capital Punjab grudgingly shares with Haryana, to build a separate Vidhan Sabha. Opponents questioned the logic, claiming the existing Vidhan Sabha belongs to Punjab and by demanding separate land to build a new one, Mann had weakened the state's claim on Chandigarh.

Many do believe the CM is on the right track. Several former bureaucrats told INDIA TODAY that there is a genuine effort to improve governance and get a grip on law and order—and that it will take time to show results. A cohesive plan is needed to bust the gangster nexus whose imprint spans drug trafficking, smuggling, extortion and Khalistan-related violence. For now, perceptions are being moulded by dramatic incidents like the Sidhu Moosewala murder, the rocket-propelled grenade attack at the Punjab Police in-

MONEY MATTERS

₹2.84 LAKH CRORE
Current debt of Punjab govt; likely to go up to Rs 3.05 lakh cr. by FY23 end

₹95,400 CRORE
Estimated revenues of Punjab for 2022-23

₹14,000 CRORE
Funds allocated for school education in the budget for 2022-23

₹1,800 CRORE
Funds required in addition to the Rs 3,988 crore earmarked to give free 300 units of electricity to every household